



The Great Wall: A Monument Through Time

【TED科普：万里长城永不倒：为什么长城这么特殊？】

Summary: The Great Wall of China, originally built by feudal states and unified by Emperor Qin Shi Huang, spans over 13,000 miles as a defense against northern invasions.

Constructed by conscripted laborers and soldiers, it became a symbol of suffering with countless deaths recorded during its expansion. Though breached by Mongol invaders, the Ming Dynasty reinforced it with brick watchtowers featuring advanced signaling systems. After the Qing Dynasty rendered it obsolete, sections were repurposed for WWII defense. Now a UNESCO World Heritage Site, it attracts millions of tourists despite preservation challenges, and remains a cultural icon despite the myth about its visibility from space.

摘要：中国长城最初由战国诸侯修建，经秦始皇连接扩建，形成超过1.3万英里的北方防线。这座由强制征召的劳工和士兵建造的巨墙，在历代扩建过程中成为无数劳动者血泪的象征。虽曾被蒙古铁骑攻破，明朝仍用砖石加固并建起配备烽火台的防御体系。清朝建立后长城军事功能衰退，但二战期间仍被用作抗日防线。如今作为世界文化遗产，尽管面临旅游损耗和“太空可见”的误读，它仍是人类文明史上的奇迹。





🕒 Estimated Reading Time: 5 min.

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▶ A 13,000-mile dragon of Earth and stone winds its way through the countryside of China.

一条长达13000英里的土石#巨龙#蜿蜒穿过中国乡野

▶ Its history is almost as long and serpentine as its structure.

其历史几乎如建筑本身般悠长而#曲折#

▶ The Great Wall began as multiple walls of rammed Earth.

长城最初由多段夯土墙组成

▶ They were built by individual feudal states during the Trenchou period.

由战国时期各个#封建#诸侯国修建

▶ They were built to protect against nomadic raiders north of China and each other.

既为抵御北方#游牧#民族侵袭 也为防范诸侯国相互攻伐

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▶ When Emperor Qing Shi Huang unified the states in 221 BCE,

当#秦始皇#于公元前221年#统一#六国时

▶ the Tibetan Plateau and Pacific Ocean became natural barriers.

青藏#高原#与太平洋已成为天然屏障

▶ But the mountains in the north remained vulnerable to Mongol, Turkish and Xiong Ngu invasions.

但北方山脉仍#易受#蒙古、突厥和匈奴侵袭

▶ To defend against them, the Emperor expanded the small walls built by his predecessors.

为加强防御，#帝王#扩建了前人所筑城墙

▶ He connected some and fortifying others.

连点成线 固旧筑新

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▶ As the structures grew from Ling Tao in the west to Liu Dong in the east,

当建筑群西起临洮东至辽东

▶ they collectively became known as the Long Wall.

这些城墙#统称为#万里长城

▶ To accomplish this task, the Emperor enlisted soldiers and commoners.

为#完成#此工程，#帝王#征募士兵与平民

▶ This was not always voluntarily.

多为强制征调

▶ Of the hundreds of thousands of builders recorded during the Qing Dynasty, many were forcibly conscripted peasants.

秦朝记载的数十万筑城者中 多为强征的农民

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▶ Others were criminals serving out sentences.

其余则为服刑囚犯

▶ Under the Han Dynasty, the Wall grew longer still.

至汉朝时期 长城继续延伸

▶ It reached 3,700 miles and spanning from Duan Huang to the Bo Hai Sea.

西起敦煌东至渤海 绵延3700英里

▶ Forced laborer continued under the Han Emperor Hang Wu Die.

汉武帝统治时期仍沿用强制劳役

▶ The Wall's reputation grew into a notorious place of suffering.

长城渐成恶名昭彰的苦难之地

▶ Poems and legends of the time told of laborers buried in nearby mass graves.

当时诗作传说皆言劳工被埋于附近乱葬岗

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▶ They were even buried within the Wall itself.

甚有尸骨直接砌入墙垣

▶ And while no human remains have been found inside, grave pits do indicate that many workers died.

虽未发现墙内遗骸 但墓穴坑洞证实众多劳工死亡

▶ They died from accidents, hunger and exhaustion.

死因包括事故、#饥饿#与过度劳累

▶ The Wall was formidable, but not invincible.

长城虽#坚固异常# 却非#不可攻克#

▶ Both Genghis and his son, Kublacon, managed to surmount the Wall.

成吉思汗与其子忽必烈均曾成功#越过#长城

▶ This was during the Mongol invasion of the 13th century.

正值13世纪蒙古#入侵#时期

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▶ After the Ming Dynasty gained control in 1368, they began to re-fortify and further consolidate the Wall.

1368年明朝掌权后 着手重新#加固#并#巩固#长城

▶ They used bricks and stones from local kilns.

采用当地窑烧砖石

▶ Averaging 23 feet high and 21 feet wide, the Wall's 5,500 miles were punctuated by watchtowers.

墙体平均高23英尺宽21英尺 5500英里防线上烽火台星罗棋布

▶ When raiders were sighted, fire and smoke signals traveled between towers.

敌寇来袭时 烽火信号穿梭于台楼之间

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▶ This continued until reinforcements arrived.

直至援军抵达

▶ Small openings along the Wall let archers fire on invaders.

墙身箭孔供射手射杀敌军

▶ Larger ones were used to drop stones and more.

较大孔洞用于投掷滚石等防御

▶ But even this new and improved Wall was not enough.

然此升级版长城仍不足御敌

▶ In 1644, northern Manchu clans overthrew the Ming to establish the Qing Dynasty.

1644年满族部落推翻明朝建立清#朝#

▶ They incorporated Mongolia as well.

同时兼并蒙古

▶ Thus, for the second time, China was ruled by the very people the Wall had tried to keep out.

历史上第二次 长城试图阻挡的民族成为了中原统治者

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▶ With the Empire's borders now extending beyond the Great Wall, the fortifications lost their purpose.

因帝国疆域扩展至长城以外 防御工事失去意义

▶ And without regular reinforcement, the Wall fell into disrepair.

缺乏定期维护 长城日渐破败

▶ Rammed earth eroded.

夯土风化

▶ Brick and stone were plundered for building materials.

砖石被拆作建材

▶ But its job wasn't finished.

然其使命未终

▶ During World War II, China used sections for defense against Japanese invasion.

二战期间中国凭借部分段落抵御日本#入侵#

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▶ And some parts are still rumored to be used for military training.

传闻某些路段至今仍用于军事训练

▶ But the Wall's main purpose today is cultural.

如今长城主要承载文化功能

▶ As one of the largest man-made structures on earth, it was granted UNESCO World Heritage Status in 1987.

作为地球最大人造建筑之一 1987年获封联合国教科文组织世界#遗产#

▶ Originally built to keep people out of China, the Great Wall now welcomes millions of visitors each year.

昔为御敌于国门之外 今迎万千游客往来

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▶ In fact, the influx of tourists has caused the Wall to deteriorate.

事实上游客#涌入#反使城墙#恶化#

▶ This has led the Chinese government to launch preservation initiatives.

中国政府由此推行#保护#计划

▶ It's also often acclaimed as the only man-made structure visible from space.

常被誉为唯一可从太空可见的人造建筑

▶ Unfortunately, that's not at all true.

此说实为谬误

▶ In low earth orbit, all sorts of structures, like bridges, highways, and airports are visible.

在近地#轨道#上 桥梁高速公路机场等皆可见

▶ And the Great Wall is only barely discernible.

长城仅勉强#可辨#

▶ From the moon, it doesn't stand a chance.

自月球观测则绝无可能

▶ But regardless, it's the earth we should be studying it from.

我们更应立足地球端详其伟貌

▶ Because new sections are still discovered every few years.

因每隔数年便有新段被发现

▶ They branch off from the main body.

自主体延伸而出

▶ They expand this remarkable monument to human achievement.

持续拓展着这座人类伟绩的非凡#丰碑#

